



KAZAKHSTAN

Capital city: Astana

Area: 1,049,150 sq miles
(2,717,300 sq km)

Population: 15,400,000

Official language: Kazakh

Major religions: Muslim
47%, Christian 44%,
other 9%

Government: Democracy

Currency: Tenge

Adult literacy rate: 99%

Life expectancy: 62 years

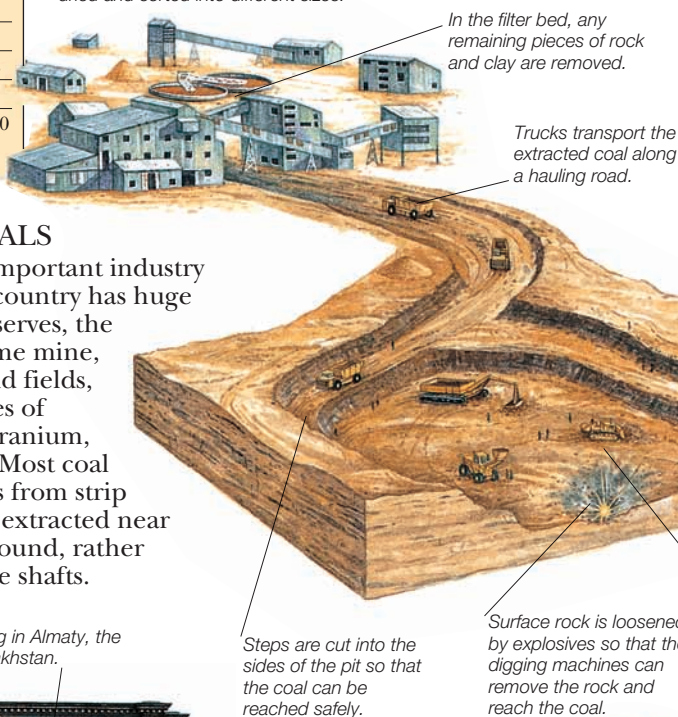
People per doctor: 278

Televisions: 231 per 1,000
people

KAZAKHSTAN

STRETCHING FROM THE Caspian Sea to China, Kazakhstan is a vast country, almost the size of western Europe. It is also one of the most underpopulated countries in the world. With vast mineral reserves, fertile soil, and a stable government, Kazakhstan has the potential to be a wealthy country. However, industrial and agricultural pollution, particularly the use of pesticides and the way in which crops like cotton are grown, have caused considerable environmental problems.

At the processing plant, the coal is cleaned and dried and sorted into different sizes.



In the filter bed, any remaining pieces of rock and clay are removed.

Trucks transport the extracted coal along a hauling road.

THE VIRGIN LANDS

In the 1950s the Russian government increased grain production by cultivating the vast grassland steppes, or plains, of Kazakhstan. Huge farms were set up to grow corn and wheat on land that had been barren. Millions of Russians migrated or were forced to move to this empty region, known as the "Virgin Lands." The program met with mixed success. It left Kazakhstan self-sufficient in grain and other crops, but it led to enormous environmental damage.

RICH IN MINERALS

Mining is the most important industry in Kazakhstan. The country has huge coal and iron-ore reserves, the world's largest chrome mine, one of its biggest gold fields, and plentiful supplies of copper, zinc, lead, uranium, and other minerals. Most coal in Kazakhstan comes from strip mines, where coal is extracted near the surface of the ground, rather than from deep mine shafts.

A government building in Almaty, the former capital of Kazakhstan.



THE CITY OF APPLES

Almaty means "father of apple trees," and the former capital is known for its apple orchards. The city nestles at the foot of the Tien Shan mountains in the far south of the country. It has many parks and fountains, and narrow canals called *aryks* run along the sides of streets to cool the city during the hot summers. The capital was moved to Astana in the north in 1994.

SPACE RACE

History was made in Kazakhstan in 1957, when the world's first artificial satellite, *Sputnik I*, was launched from the Baykonur Cosmodrome, or space station, in the center of the country. The first person in space, Yuri Gagarin, was sent into orbit around the Earth from Baykonur in 1961. The site is still used today by the Russian government for its space program.



Machines dig the coal out of the pit.

Surface rock is loosened by explosives so that the digging machines can remove the rock and reach the coal.

Steps are cut into the sides of the pit so that the coal can be reached safely.



THE KAZAKHS

Native Kazakhs make up only about 50 percent of the total population of their country and live mainly in the west and south. Many are farmers and have worked hard to preserve the natural beauty of the land, setting up reserves to protect the wildlife and environment. The rest of the population consists mainly of Russians, Germans, and Ukrainians.

Find out more

CEREALS: 34, 122

COAL MINING: 96, 114

POPULATION DENSITY: 135

STEPPE (GRASSLANDS): 15